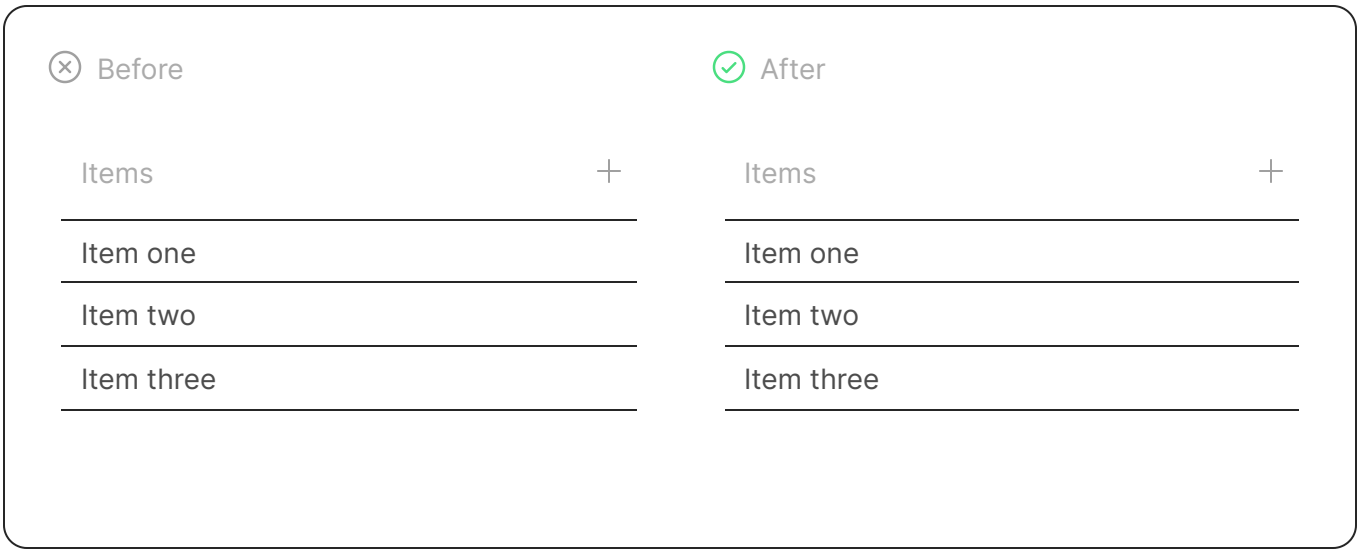
September 17 2026

A Simple Guide to Calm UI

Try adding an item to each list below.

Pay attention to what happens after you submit each dialog:



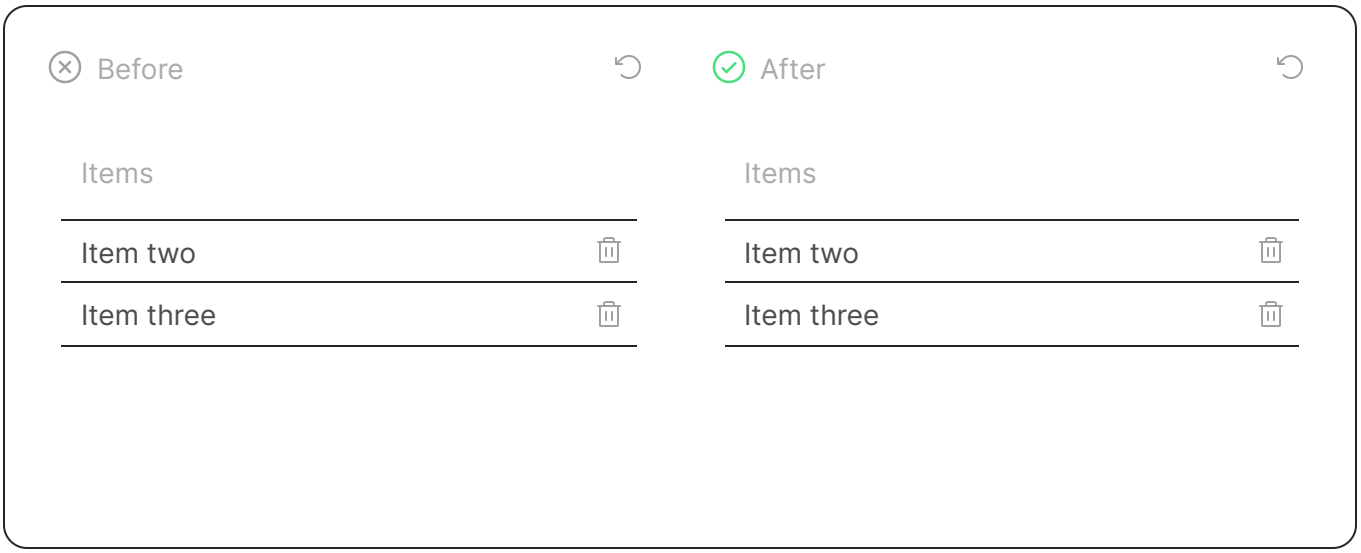
Why does the second example feel so much calmer?

The 2 Rules for Calm UI

1. Don't show cascading loading states. Keep showing the loading state on the save-button until the list in the background has been refetched.
2. Avoid using toasts. They're bad UX. Instead show your action take effect (by adding an item to the list in this case). No need for an extra confirmation.

Example: Item Deletion

Try deleting an item from each list:

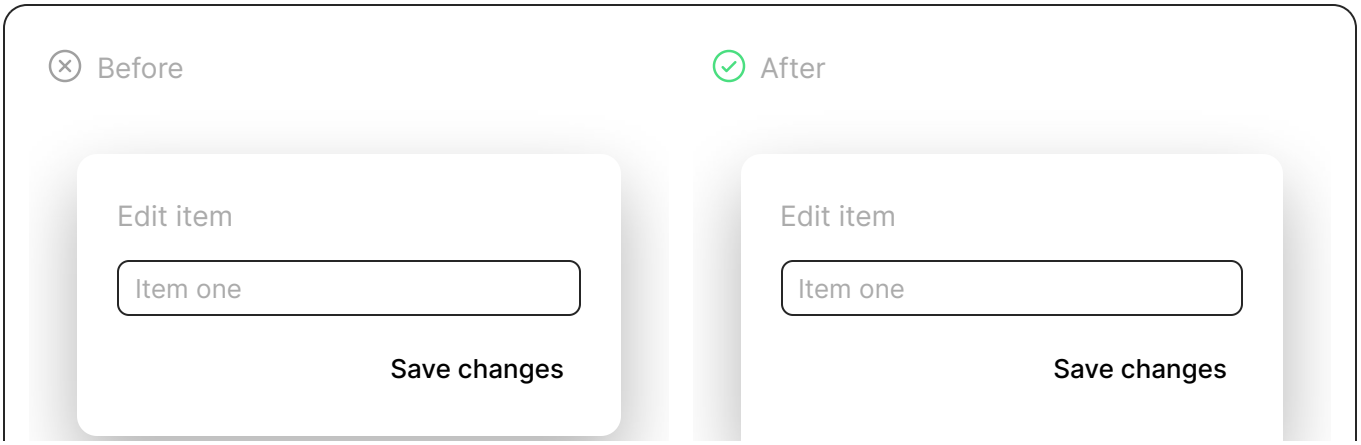


Same principle as above. Fewer discrete loading states and no toasts make for a calmer UI.

Bonus Rules

1. Don't use toasts for errors either

Try saving each item:

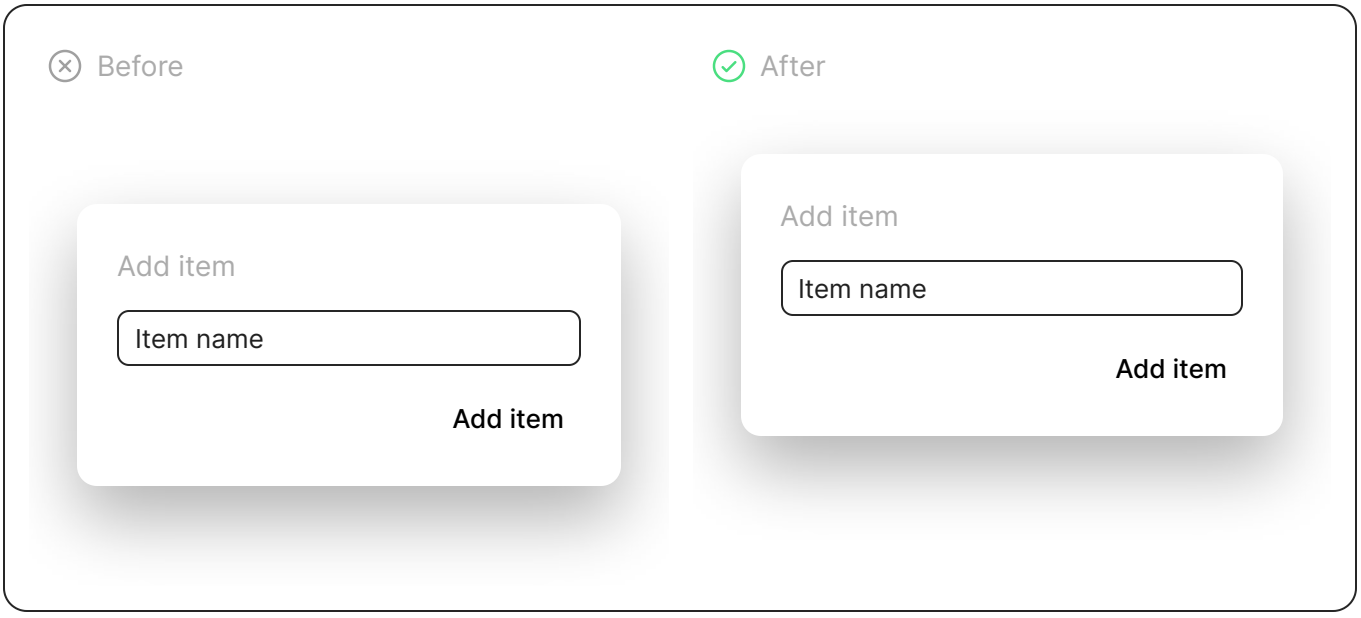


The toast might look cleaner but it will appear far away from where the user originally clicked, especially on large screens.

Toasts also disappear after a while, leaving the user confused if they weren't paying attention when the toast was shown.

2. Pin modals that change height to the top

Try submitting each dialog below a few times:

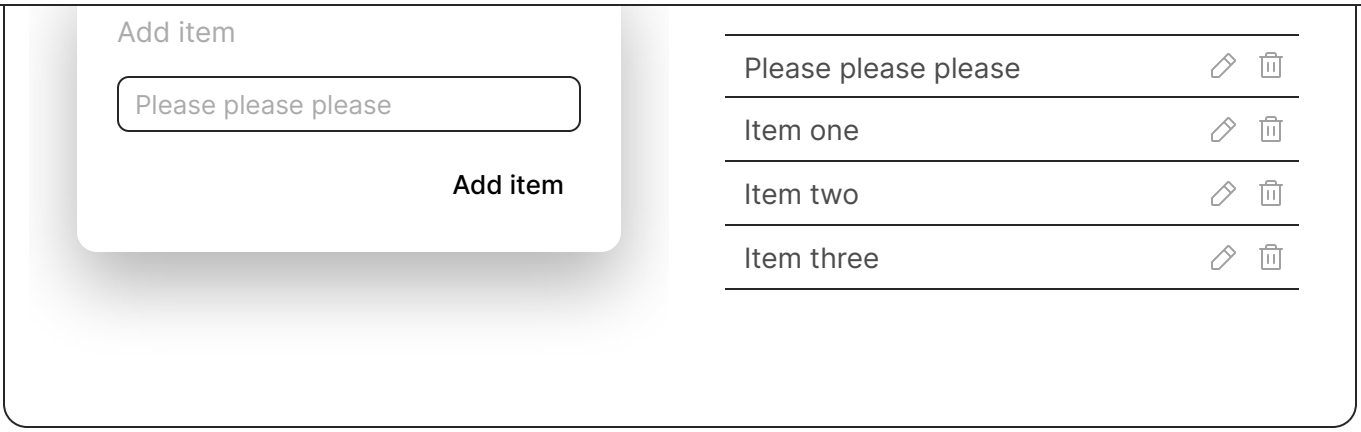


When the modal is centered, it causes the submit-button to shift position when showing/hiding the error message. Annoying!

The simple solution is to pin the modal to the top.

3. Let 'Enter' submit the form

Type in a name for the item and try hitting `Enter` on your keyboard:

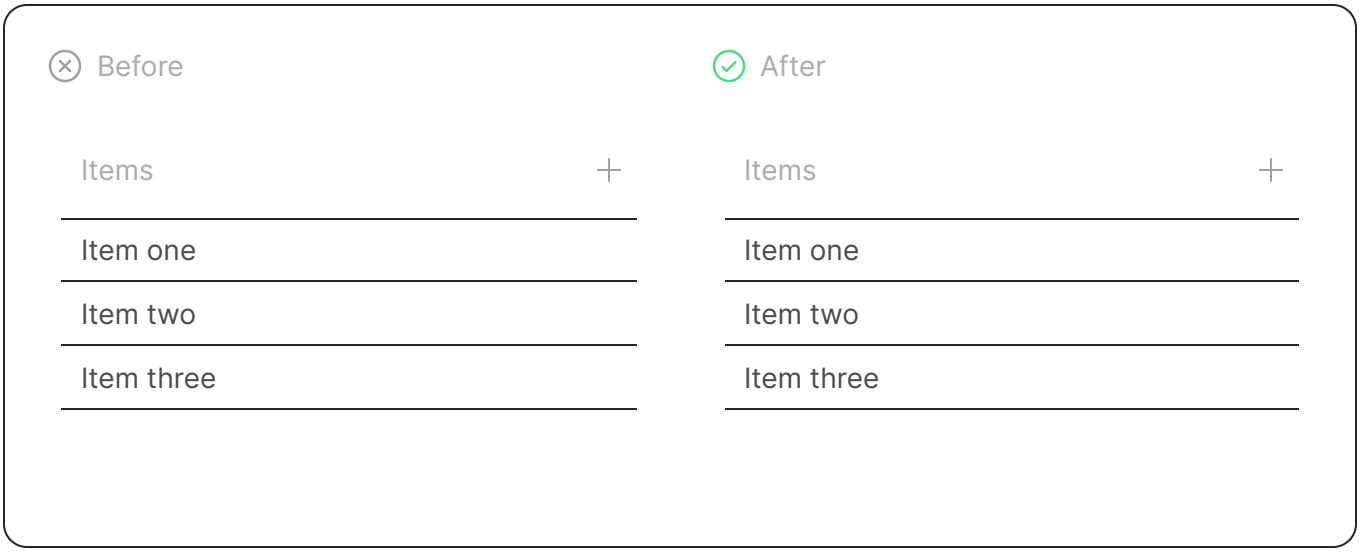


When you're typing in the name of your item, you should be able to just hit `Enter` to submit the form.

You get this for free in React by using `<form onSubmit={addItem}>` instead of `<button onClick={addItem}>`.

4. Focus first input when opening a dialog

Try adding an item to each list and count how many clicks it takes:



It's super annoying when I click to open a dialog and I have to click again so I can start typing.

There are many great design engineers writing about the more subtle art of design, like Jakub Krehel (The invisible side of design engineering) and Emil Kowalski (7 Practical Animation Tips).

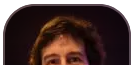
I love that stuff but often times we have to build simple, solid UI and don't have the luxury of sweating the tiniest details.

And yes, even the `After` examples above could be polished a whole lot more with nice animations, optimistic updates, inline editing, etc.

This article was trying to show a few basic rules to keep in mind to make simple UIs feel a lot better. Without costing you extra time (or tokens).

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